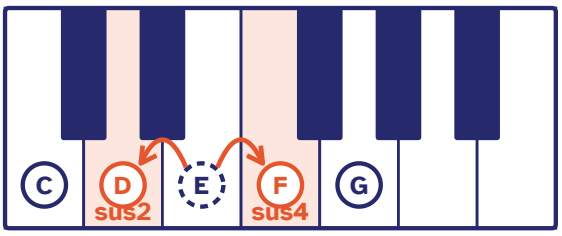
PART V · CHORDS · 6

Colour chords

The 3rd is the chord's mood switch: major or minor, happy or sad. But chords have more colours than happy and sad.

THE SECRET

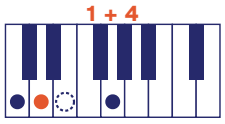
Move the 3rd, take it away, or add one note: five new colours.



1. Start from **C E G**. The **E** (the 3rd) makes it major.
2. Slide the E up to the next letter, **F**: **Csus4**.
3. Or down to the letter below, **D**: **Csus2**. With no 3rd, the chord is neither major nor minor: it **hangs in the air**.

Five colours, all on C

Csus2

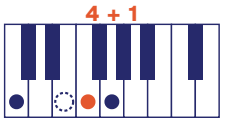


C D G

open

the 3rd steps down

Csus4

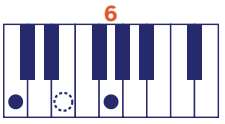


C F G

floating

the 3rd steps up

C5

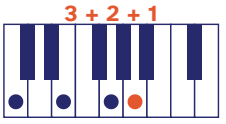


C G

strong

no 3rd at all

C6

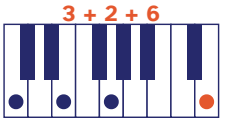


C E G A

warm

add the 6th

Cadd9

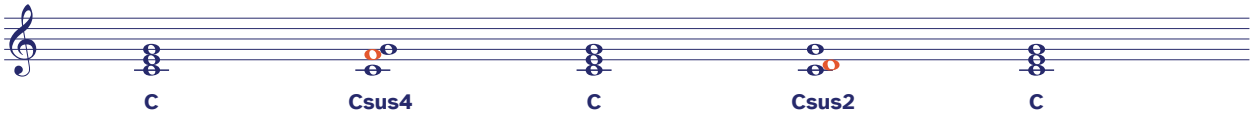


C E G D

sparkly

add the 9th on top

Lean, then slide back



The red note leans, then slides back to E: F steps down, D steps up. Play it slowly: C, Csus4, C, Csus2, C. Guitarists love this shimmer.

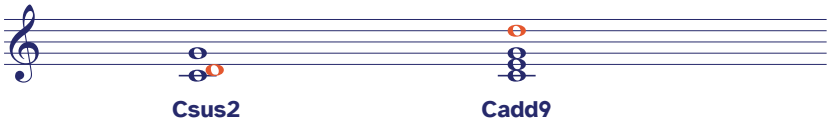
On any root, the counts stay the same

COLOUR	KEYS BETWEEN	ON C	ON G	ON F	ON D
sus2	1 + 4	C D G	G A D	F G C	D E A
sus4	4 + 1	C F G	G C D	F B♭ C	D G A
5	6	C G	G D	F C	D A
6	3 + 2 + 1	C E G **A**	G B D **E**	F A C **D**	D F♯ A **B**
add9	3 + 2 + 6	C E G **D**	G B D **A**	F A C **G**	D F♯ A **E**

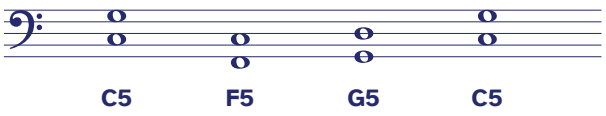
PART V · CHORDS · 6 · CONTINUED

sus: the 3rd held up or down · **5**: no 3rd at all · **6** and **add9**: one note added on top. Csus means Csus4.

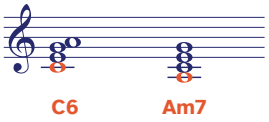
Spot the difference



The same red D, two jobs. Csus2 throws the E out; Cadd9 keeps the E and puts the D on top.



The power chord: just the root and the 5th, played low in the left hand. With no 3rd it is neither happy nor sad, only **strong**: the sound of rock guitar. Play C5, F5, G5, C5 and drum the rhythm.



C6 or Am7? The same four notes, C E G A. The red bottom note decides: C at the bottom is **C6**; A at the bottom is **Am7**. More on the bass note in Slash chords, p. 131.

EXAMPLE 1

Which colour is it? G C D



1. **Count the keys between:** G to C, then C to D.
2. **Find the card** with the same two numbers.
3. **Is there a 3rd (B)?** What has taken its place?

4 + 1, no B: G C D is **Gsus4**. Swap the C for **B** and you have G major.

GAME

sus2, sus4 or add9?

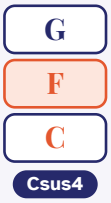
1	2	3
C D G	C F G	C E G D

In a sus chord the 3rd has moved; in an add chord nothing moved and a note was added.

Answer: 1 Csus2 · 2 Csus4 · 3 Cadd9.

PART V · CHORDS · 6 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

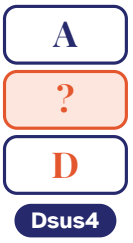


Csus4, then C.

Play C F G, then C E G. No 3rd, then a 3rd: floating, then bright.

EXAMPLE 2

Build Dsus4

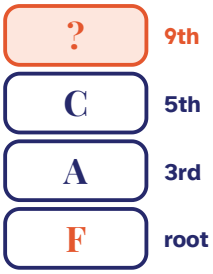


1. **Start with D major:** D F♯ A.
2. **sus4:** move the middle layer up to the next letter.
3. **Which key is it?**

F♯ moves up to **G**: Dsus4 is **D G A**.

EXAMPLE 3

Build Fadd9



1. **Start with F major:** F A C, and keep every note.
2. **The 9th** is the 2nd, an octave up: which letter comes just after F?
3. **Put it on top.**

Fadd9: F A C **G**. Nothing moved; one note was added.

THINK OF IT Decorating the cake: a ribbon (the 6th) or a candle (the 9th) and it is still the same cake. Sus moves its middle layer; a power chord takes the middle layer out.

TRAP

× Calling Cadd9 a ninth chord: C9 also has the 7th (B♭). Add9 is just the triad plus the 9th (D on C), nothing else (The tower, p. 128).

SEE ALSO
Four kinds of triad p. 113 · Seventh chords p. 122

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 11–12 · Online: Library › Chords